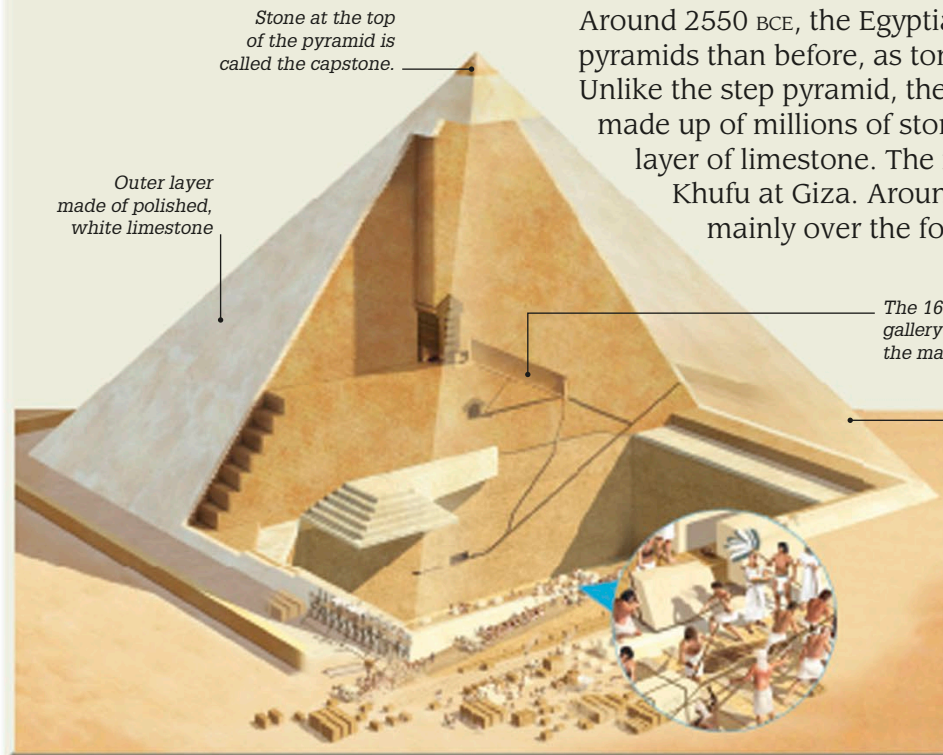


2550 BCE

GREAT PYRAMIDS



Stone at the top of the pyramid is called the capstone.

Outer layer made of polished, white limestone

Around 2550 BCE, the Egyptians began building much larger pyramids than before, as tombs for their dead pharaohs. Unlike the step pyramid, these were smooth-sided, and made up of millions of stone blocks covered with a smooth layer of limestone. The first was the Great Pyramid of Khufu at Giza. Around 100 pyramids were built, mainly over the following 300 years.

The 164-ft- (50-m-) long grand gallery leads to the King's Chamber, the main burial chamber.

The pyramid may weigh more than 5.5 million tons (5 million metric tons).

How they were built

The Great Pyramid is made up of two million limestone blocks, which were quarried in the nearby desert and then dragged to Giza on wooden rollers. It was constructed one level at a time. Ramps were probably used to transport the blocks up to higher levels.

2400

2400 BCE

Invention of the shaduf

The shaduf, a device for raising water for irrigation, was invented in Mesopotamia and later also used in Egypt. It had an upright frame with a pole onto which a bucket was attached. A farmer lowered the pole to scoop up a bucketful of water from a channel. The shaduf was then rotated and lowered again to tip the water into another channel, often at a different level.



Wall painting of a peasant drawing water with a shaduf, c 1200 BCE

2200

2100 BCE

Development of the calendar

The earliest-known calendar is the Umma calendar of Shulgi, devised by the Sumerians (people from Sumer, now in southern Iraq). It had 12 months of 29 or 30 days, making 354 days in total. To keep the calendar in line with the real 365.25-day solar year, the Sumerians added a month every few years.



Ziggurat of Ur

2200 BCE

Building of ziggurats

The people of Mesopotamia built the first ziggurats: monumental, pyramid-shaped temples made up of several layers connected by stepped terraces. Ziggurats housed shrines to the gods. Their construction involved huge amounts of material and manpower.